

5K Running Training Plan

12-Week Beginner Program

Race Distance: 5 kilometers (3.1 miles)

Target Audience: Complete beginners with no running experience

Prerequisites: Basic fitness level (able to walk 30 minutes)

Weekly Training: 3-4 days per week | 2-4 hours total

Program Structure: 3 cycles with progressive intensity

Program Overview

This 12-week beginner-friendly program takes you from zero to 5K race ready. The plan uses a run/walk approach, gradually increasing running intervals while decreasing walk breaks. By race day, you'll be able to run the full 5K distance.

Key Principles:

- Run/walk intervals gradually transition to continuous running
 - 3-4 training days per week with rest days for recovery
 - Progressive volume increases (no more than 10% per week)
 - Injury prevention through proper warm-up and cool-down
 - Flexibility to adjust based on how you feel
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CYCLE 1: BASE BUILDING (Weeks 1-4)

Week 1: Introduction to Running

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk Introduction (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 1 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 1 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (30 min)

- Entire session conversational pace

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~1.5 hours

Week 2: Increase Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 5 times)

- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (35 min)

- Entire session conversational pace

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

Week 3: Build Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 3 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 3 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (40 min)

- Entire session conversational pace

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

Week 4: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 2 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 4 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~1.5 hours

CYCLE 2: BUILDING ENDURANCE (Weeks 5-8)

Week 5: Longer Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 5 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 3 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 5 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 3 times)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (45 min)

- Entire session conversational pace

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 6: Extended Running Intervals

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 7 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 2 times), then 5 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: Alternate 7 min running, 2 min walking (repeat 2 times), then 5 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (45 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 7: Transition to Continuous Running

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min running, 2 min walking, 10 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min running, 2 min walking, 10 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (50 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 8: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 8 min running, 2 min walking, 8 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Run/Walk (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 8 min running, 2 min walking, 8 min running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Walk (40 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

CYCLE 3: RACE PREPARATION (Weeks 9-12)

Week 9: Continuous 5K

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 10: Build to 5K Distance

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min continuous easy running (approximately 5K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 11: Peak Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min continuous easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 12: RACE WEEK

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (15 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Rest day - Final preparations

- Lay out all gear
- Review race course
- Early bed time

Sunday: RACE DAY!

- Arrive 30 min early
- Warm up gently with 5 min walk + 5 min easy jog
- Trust your 12 weeks of training
- Have fun and enjoy the experience!

Weekly Volume: ~0.5 hours

Running Pacing Guidelines

Easy Pace: You should be able to hold a conversation comfortably. This is your primary training pace.

Conversational Pace: Similar to easy pace, used for longer runs and recovery sessions.

Race Pace: The pace you plan to run the 5K. You can speak in short sentences but not full conversations.

Nutrition for Running

Pre-Run (1-2 hours before):

- Banana with almond butter

- Toast with jam
- Rice cakes with honey
- Small bowl of oatmeal

During Run (sessions >45 min):

- Water with electrolytes
- Sports drink if available

Post-Run (within 30 min):

- Protein + carbs (chicken with rice, protein smoothie, turkey sandwich)
 - Rehydrate with water or electrolyte drink
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Injury Prevention

Warm-up: Always start with 5 minutes of easy walking before running.

Cool-down: Always end with 5 minutes of easy walking after running.

Stretching: Stretch for 10-15 minutes after each run, focusing on calves, hamstrings, quads, and hip flexors.

Rest Days: Take at least 2-3 complete rest days per week. Your body adapts during rest, not during training.

Listen to Your Body: If you experience sharp pain (not just muscle soreness), take an extra rest day or consult a healthcare provider.

Race Week Checklist

- ☐ Lay out all gear the night before
- ☐ Check weather forecast
- ☐ Review race course map
- ☐ Plan parking and arrival time

- ☐ Practice race-day breakfast
- ☐ Get good sleep 2-3 nights before
- ☐ Reduce training volume by 70%
- ☐ Eat familiar foods only
- ☐ Hydrate consistently
- ☐ Arrive 30 minutes early on race day

Remember: This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. You've got this! 🏃